



CHILD PROTECTION AND SAFEGUARDING (CPP) POLICY

Organization:

ASABA MEMORIAL EDUCATION FOUNDATION (AMEF)

Policy Title:

Child Protection and Safeguarding (CPP) Policy

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Approved on behalf of the AMEF Founding Body;

Name: Mr. Bienvenu Byamungu

Position: Chairperson, Founding Body

Signature:  _____

Review Date: 10th June, 2029

CHILD PROTECTION AND SAFEGUARDING (CPP) POLICYs

1. INTRODUCTION

Asaba Memorial Education Foundation (AMEF) is committed to promoting the rights, safety, dignity and wellbeing of children and young people.

AMEF recognizes that children may face risks of abuse, neglect, exploitation, violence, discrimination and other forms of harm, particularly where they are vulnerable because of poverty, disability, family circumstances, school dropout or other social and economic challenges.

AMEF therefore places child protection and safeguarding at the centre of all programmes and activities involving children.

This Policy establishes the principles, standards, responsibilities and procedures that AMEF will follow to prevent harm to children, respond appropriately to concerns and create safe environments in which children can learn, participate and develop.

The policy applies particularly to AMEF's work through **Asaba Memorial High School (AMHS)** and to future community programmes involving children and young people.

2. POLICY STATEMENT

AMEF has **zero tolerance for all forms of child abuse, exploitation, violence, neglect and harmful practices.**

AMEF is committed to:

- Protecting children from harm;
- Promoting children's rights and dignity;
- Preventing abuse and exploitation;
- Ensuring safe learning and training environments;
- Responding promptly and appropriately to safeguarding concerns;
- Ensuring that staff, volunteers, trainers, partners and other representatives understand their safeguarding responsibilities;
- Promoting children's participation in decisions that affect them;
- Maintaining confidentiality while ensuring that safeguarding concerns are properly reported and acted upon.

The safety and best interests of children shall take precedence in all AMEF programmes and decisions involving children.

3. PURPOSE OF THE POLICY

The purpose of this Policy is to:

1. Establish AMEF's commitment to child protection.
2. Define unacceptable conduct towards children.
3. Establish procedures for preventing child abuse and exploitation.
4. Provide clear procedures for reporting and responding to safeguarding concerns.
5. Establish responsibilities for staff, volunteers, trainers and partners.
6. Promote safe environments within AMEF programmes and facilities.
7. Protect children participating in education, vocational training, community outreach and other activities.
8. Ensure appropriate referral of cases to competent authorities and service providers.
9. Promote accountability and continuous improvement in safeguarding practice.

4. SCOPE OF THE POLICY

This Policy applies to everyone working with or representing AMEF, including:

- Board members;
- Management;
- Employees;
- Teachers where engaged under AMEF programmes;
- Trainers and instructors;
- Volunteers;
- Interns;
- Consultants;
- Contractors;

- Community facilitators;
- Project staff;
- Drivers and support personnel;
- Visitors participating in AMEF activities;
- Partner organisations and implementing partners where applicable.

The Policy applies to activities conducted:

- At Asaba Memorial High School;
- At AMEF offices;
- At vocational training facilities;
- During community outreach;
- During field activities;
- During educational activities;
- During workshops and training;
- During trips, excursions and events;
- Through digital and online platforms;
- During any activity organised, supported or funded by AMEF.

5. WHO IS A CHILD?

For the purposes of this Policy, a **child is any person below the age of 18 years.**

AMEF shall provide appropriate protection to all children participating in its programmes regardless of their:

- Sex or gender;
- Disability;
- Social or economic background;
- Family circumstances;
- Religion;
- Ethnicity;

- Nationality;
- School status; or
- Other personal circumstances.

6. CHILD PROTECTION PRINCIPLES

AMEF will be guided by the following principles.

6.1 Best Interests of the Child

All decisions affecting a child shall give primary consideration to the child's safety, wellbeing and best interests.

6.2 Do No Harm

AMEF programmes shall be designed and implemented in ways that minimize risks of harm to children.

6.3 Non-Discrimination

Every child shall be treated fairly and with dignity.

6.4 Child Participation

Children should be appropriately informed and given opportunities to express their views in matters affecting them, taking account of their age and maturity.

6.5 Confidentiality

Information concerning safeguarding cases shall be handled sensitively and shared only with people who need the information to protect the child or facilitate appropriate response.

6.6 Accountability

Everyone representing AMEF has a responsibility to uphold this Policy and report concerns.

7. FORMS OF ABUSE AND HARM

AMEF recognizes the following forms of child abuse and harm:

7.1 Physical Abuse

Any act that causes or may cause physical injury or pain to a child.

Examples include:

- Hitting;

- Beating;
- Kicking;
- Burning;
- Corporal punishment;
- Deliberately causing physical injury.

7.2 Sexual Abuse and Exploitation

Any sexual activity involving a child or any conduct that sexually exploits or exposes a child.

This includes:

- Sexual contact;
- Sexual assault;
- Sexual exploitation;
- Grooming;
- Sexual harassment;
- Exposing children to sexual content;
- Taking or sharing sexual images of children;
- Online sexual exploitation.

7.3 Emotional or Psychological Abuse

Conduct that seriously harms a child's emotional wellbeing or development.

Examples include:

- Threats;
- Humiliation;
- Intimidation;
- Persistent insults;
- Degrading treatment;
- Deliberate isolation.

7.4 Neglect

Failure to provide reasonable care, supervision, protection or essential support required for a child's wellbeing.

7.5 Exploitation

Using a child for another person's benefit in ways that harm or place the child at risk.

7.6 Child Labour and Hazardous Work

AMEF will not knowingly expose children to exploitative, hazardous or inappropriate labour.

7.7 Bullying

AMEF does not tolerate bullying, intimidation, harassment or discriminatory behaviour among children or by adults towards children.

7.8 Online Harm

AMEF recognizes risks arising from:

- Online grooming;
- Cyberbullying;
- Sexual exploitation;
- Unauthorized sharing of children's images;
- Contact with inappropriate persons;
- Exposure to harmful content.

8. CODE OF CONDUCT FOR WORKING WITH CHILDREN

All AMEF representatives working with children must:

- Treat children with dignity and respect.
- Maintain appropriate professional boundaries.
- Use appropriate and respectful language.
- Avoid behaviour that could reasonably be interpreted as inappropriate.
- Avoid being alone with a child where this can reasonably be avoided.
- Conduct activities in observable and appropriately supervised environments.

- Obtain appropriate authorization before photographing or recording children.
- Protect children's personal information.
- Report safeguarding concerns promptly.
- Follow AMEF's safeguarding procedures.

Prohibited Conduct

AMEF representatives must never:

- Hit or physically punish a child;
- Engage in sexual activity or sexualized behaviour with a child;
- Make sexual comments to or about a child;
- Groom a child;
- Exchange inappropriate personal messages with children;
- Give inappropriate gifts, money or favours in exchange for personal attention;
- Invite children to private residences without appropriate authorization;
- Use humiliating or degrading punishment;
- Exploit children for personal, financial or organizational benefit;
- Take or share inappropriate photographs of children;
- Consume alcohol or illegal drugs while responsible for children;
- Ignore or conceal safeguarding concerns.

9. SAFE RECRUITMENT

AMEF will take reasonable steps to ensure that people engaged in work involving children are suitable for their roles.

Depending on the position, recruitment procedures may include:

- Verification of identity;
- Review of qualifications and experience;
- Reference checks;
- Interviews;

- Declaration of safeguarding responsibilities;
- Appropriate background checks where available and applicable;
- Signing of the AMEF Child Protection Code of Conduct.

Any safeguarding concern arising during recruitment shall be appropriately considered before engagement.

10. TRAINING AND AWARENESS

AMEF will promote awareness of child protection among:

- Staff;
- Trainers;
- Volunteers;
- Teachers involved in AMEF programmes;
- Board members;
- Community facilitators;
- Partners.

Relevant personnel shall be oriented on:

- Child protection principles;
- Recognizing signs of abuse;
- Appropriate conduct;
- Reporting procedures;
- Confidentiality;
- Referral mechanisms;
- Online safety;
- Safeguarding responsibilities.

11. REPORTING CHILD PROTECTION CONCERNS

Anyone who becomes aware of or suspects that a child is being abused, exploited, neglected or otherwise placed at risk should report the concern through AMEF's safeguarding reporting mechanism.

A person reporting a concern is not required to investigate the matter or prove that abuse occurred.

The responsibility of AMEF personnel is to:

Recognize → Report → Record appropriately → Refer → Follow up

12. INTERNAL REPORTING

AMEF shall designate a **Child Protection/Safeguarding Focal Person** responsible for receiving and coordinating safeguarding concerns.

A concern may be reported to:

Name: Jili Zawadi

Position: Child Protection and PSEAH Focal Person

Telephone: +256782673446

Email: childprotection@amefuganda.org

Where the concern involves the Safeguarding Focal Person, the matter shall be reported directly to the Executive Director/Chief Executive Officer or another designated senior authority.

Where the concern involves senior management, it shall be reported to the Board or designated Board representative.

13. EXTERNAL REFERRAL

Where a safeguarding concern indicates that a child may have suffered abuse, exploitation or serious harm, AMEF shall make an appropriate referral to relevant authorities and professional services.

Depending on the circumstances, these may include:

- Local Child Protection structures;
- Probation and Social Welfare Officer;
- Police/Child and Family Protection Unit;
- Health facilities;
- District authorities;
- Other competent child-protection service providers.

Uganda's National Children's Authority has a mandate to support coordination and protection of children's rights, while the Government's Child Helpline 116

provides a 24/7 toll-free reporting and referral mechanism for child abuse and child-rights violations.

Uganda Child Helpline: 116

14. RESPONDING TO A DISCLOSURE BY A CHILD

If a child discloses abuse or a safeguarding concern:

DO:

- Listen calmly.
- Take the child seriously.
- Reassure the child that they did the right thing by speaking.
- Explain that you may need to share the information with people who can help protect them.
- Record the information accurately.
- Report the concern promptly.

DO NOT:

- Blame the child.
- Interrogate the child.
- Ask leading questions.
- Promise absolute confidentiality.
- Investigate the allegation yourself.
- Confront the alleged perpetrator.
- Delay reporting.

15. CONFIDENTIALITY AND DATA PROTECTION

AMEF shall protect information relating to children and safeguarding cases.

Information shall:

- Be collected only when necessary;
- Be stored securely;
- Be accessible only to authorized persons;

- Not be shared unnecessarily;
- Be shared with relevant authorities or service providers when necessary to protect the child.

Records concerning safeguarding incidents shall be maintained securely and separately from general programme records where appropriate.

16. PHOTOGRAPHY, VIDEO AND CHILDREN'S IMAGES

AMEF recognizes that photographs and videos can support communication and fundraising but can also expose children to risks.

Before photographing or publishing identifiable images of children, AMEF shall seek appropriate consent/authorization and consider the child's safety and dignity.

AMEF will not knowingly publish images that:

- Humiliate or degrade children;
- Present children as helpless victims;
- Reveal sensitive personal information;
- Expose children to unnecessary risks;
- Are sexualized or inappropriate.

Images should be used in ways that respect the dignity and privacy of children.

17. CHILD PARTICIPATION

AMEF encourages children to participate safely in activities that affect them.

Children should be given age-appropriate opportunities to:

- Express their views;
- Ask questions;
- Provide feedback;
- Raise concerns;
- Participate in educational and community activities.

Participation shall never place children at additional risk.

18. SAFEGUARDING IN VOCATIONAL TRAINING

Because AMEF operates and intends to expand vocational skills programmes, additional safeguarding measures shall apply to practical training.

These include:

- Appropriate supervision of learners;
- Safe use of tools and equipment;
- Age-appropriate activities;
- Appropriate protective equipment;
- Safe workshop environments;
- Clear instructor-learner boundaries;
- No corporal punishment;
- Appropriate procedures for accidents and injuries.

For activities such as **carpentry, joinery and concrete brick making**, particular attention shall be given to machinery, tools, heavy materials and other physical hazards.

19. PARTNERS AND CONTRACTORS

AMEF expects organisations, trainers, consultants and other partners working with children on its behalf to uphold appropriate safeguarding standards.

Where appropriate, agreements with partners shall include child protection requirements.

AMEF may suspend or terminate engagement with an individual or organization where serious safeguarding violations are identified.

20. CHILDREN WITH DISABILITIES AND OTHER VULNERABLE CHILDREN

AMEF recognizes that some children may face additional risks because of disability, poverty, family circumstances, displacement, school dropout or other vulnerabilities.

AMEF will seek to ensure that safeguarding measures are accessible and appropriate to the needs of such children.

Particular attention shall be given to children who may have difficulty reporting abuse or accessing protection services.

21. SAFEGUARDING RISK ASSESSMENT

AMEF shall consider child protection risks when designing and implementing programmes.

Risk assessments should consider:

- Location of activities;
- Age and vulnerability of participants;
- Staff and volunteer interactions;
- Transport arrangements;
- Accommodation;
- Use of tools and equipment;
- Photography and media;
- Online communication;
- Community activities;
- Partnerships.

Appropriate measures shall be implemented to reduce identified risks.

22. DISCIPLINE

AMEF prohibits corporal punishment and humiliating or degrading treatment of children.

Disciplinary measures in AMEF-supported activities should be:

- Appropriate;
- Proportionate;
- Respectful;
- Consistent with safeguarding principles;
- Focused on learning and positive behaviour.

23. RETALIATION AND WHISTLEBLOWER PROTECTION

No person should be punished, threatened or disadvantaged for reporting a genuine child protection concern in good faith.

AMEF shall take reasonable measures to protect individuals who raise safeguarding concerns from retaliation.

Knowingly making malicious or deliberately false allegations may be subject to appropriate organizational action, while ensuring that genuine concerns are never discouraged.

24. RESPONSIBILITIES

Board of Directors

The Board shall:

- Approve the Policy;
- Provide oversight;
- Ensure organizational accountability;
- Review serious safeguarding matters;
- Ensure appropriate resources for safeguarding.

Management

Management shall:

- Implement the Policy;
- Ensure staff awareness;
- Establish reporting mechanisms;
- Maintain appropriate records;
- Coordinate safeguarding responses.

Safeguarding Focal Person

The focal person shall:

- Receive concerns;
- Maintain safeguarding records;
- Coordinate referrals;
- Provide guidance to staff;
- Support safeguarding awareness;
- Report serious matters to management/Board.

Staff, Trainers and Volunteers

They shall:

- Follow this Policy;
- Maintain professional boundaries;
- Protect children from harm;
- Report concerns;
- Participate in safeguarding training.

25. CHILD PROTECTION IN AMEF'S COMMUNITY PROGRAMMES

As AMEF expands its programmes from Asaba Memorial High School into the wider Kiruli and Masindi community, child protection measures shall apply to community activities involving children.

This includes programmes involving:

- School dropouts;
- Youth;
- Young women;
- Vulnerable families;
- Skills training;
- Community outreach;
- Education support;
- Mentorship;
- Environmental activities.

Where beneficiaries are below 18 years, appropriate child protection measures shall be applied.

26. MONITORING AND REVIEW

AMEF will periodically review the implementation of this Policy.

The organization may assess:

- Whether staff understand safeguarding requirements;
- Whether reporting mechanisms are functioning;
- Whether risks are being identified;

- Whether safeguarding incidents are appropriately addressed;
- Whether training needs exist;
- Whether the Policy requires updating.

The Policy shall be reviewed at least every **three years**, or earlier where necessary.

ANNEX 1: CHILD PROTECTION CODE OF CONDUCT

I, _____, acknowledge that I have read and understood the AMEF Child Protection and Safeguarding Policy.

I agree to:

1. Treat all children with dignity and respect.
2. Protect children from abuse, exploitation and harm.
3. Maintain appropriate professional boundaries.
4. Never engage in sexual conduct with a child.
5. Never physically punish or humiliate a child.
6. Never exploit a child.
7. Report safeguarding concerns promptly.
8. Protect children's confidentiality and personal information.
9. Follow AMEF safeguarding procedures.
10. Cooperate with appropriate safeguarding investigations and referrals.

Name: _____

Position: _____

Signature: _____

Date: _____

ANNEX 2: SIMPLE SAFEGUARDING INCIDENT REPORT FORM

Date of Report: _____

Name of Reporter: _____

Contact: _____

Child's Name/Identifier: _____

Age/Approximate Age: _____

Date/Time of Incident: _____

Location: _____

Nature of Concern:

- ☐ Physical abuse
- ☐ Sexual abuse/exploitation
- ☐ Emotional abuse
- ☐ Neglect
- ☐ Bullying
- ☐ Child labour/exploitation
- ☐ Online harm
- ☐ Other: _____

Brief factual description of concern:

Immediate action taken:

Person/Authority referred to:

Signature: _____